

This Sri Lankan Tamil baker now supplies bread to the French President **P2**

SPB 80: SP CHARAN ON FINDING HIS OWN VOICE **P4**



Vertical limit

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If you were to jump through a portal of time to 15,000 BC, you would find art on cave walls. By 500 BC, in parts of the world like Greece, artists would have enclosed images within decorative frames; by 1500 AD, the Renaissance would have solidified the rectangular frame as the dominant format. The 1890s are sure to have brought cinema's near-square 1.33:1 frame, followed by wider aspect ratios in the 1950s that launched the widescreen revolution, making way for the cinema we know today.

Now return to 2026. Open a mobile application like KadhaiShorts or Jio Hotstar's Tadka, and you will encounter something equally revolutionary – series storytelling in a vertical format covering much of your smartphone screen in a 9:16 aspect ratio. That is not all. Episodes now span less than three minutes, another revolution. Welcome to the era of vertical cinema and micro-dramas.

With Instagram and YouTube getting audiences used to bite-sized vertical content, filmmakers have started to make films and shows for these platforms. While micro-dramas

With platforms betting big on micro-dramas, creators and executives speak about the highs of storytelling in a vertical, bite-sized format

have been getting popular globally in the last few years, they exist mostly as sketch videos in India. This is changing. According to a report by Ormax Media, almost 65 per cent of India's audience discovered micro-dramas within the last year; and 89 per cent of them discovered the format through social media platforms. Now, a rush of micro-drama platforms – Kuku TV, Quick TV, Chai Shots, Story TV, Tuktuki, and MX Fatafat among others – are creating gripping narratives that aim to capture your imagination without taking up much space or time.

JioHotstar has been pushing this format in a new mobile-only segment called Tadka in their application. "Audiences still love immersive long-form storytelling, but they are also looking for stories that can fit naturally into

the spaces between those larger viewing occasions. We saw an opportunity to build a new storytelling layer designed specifically for that behaviour," says Ambuj Kashyap, executive vice-president, Micro

What excites me is that this format fronts performances. I can concentrate on getting the best performances from the actors

ROHINI MOLLETI
Actor and filmmaker



Scroll away Poster of *Super Bachelors*; Rohini Molleti (below) and Vijay Varadharaj. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Those who are already doing films might hesitate to do micro-dramas because there is a taboo that this is something inferior

VIJAY VARADHARAJ
Actor, YouTuber and filmmaker

Content at JioStar.

The latest entrant to this market is KadhaiShorts, billed as the first of its kind in Tamil. Developed by the Maran Group, the app was launched in Chennai on May 28. KadhaiShorts is the brainchild of Founder Karan Dayanidhi Maran and CEO Sabarish Venkat. "Karan and I (Sabarish) started watching micro-dramas around 2022, and we thought it was addictive. In a year, it was booming in the US and China. However, a lot of the content we watched was quite similar except that there was a flip or a hook to every episode." This is when Karan asked Sabarish if audiences in India would watch similar content. "But we didn't want to copy these global models, obviously. That's when we thought we needed to do something deeply local and culturally rooted," says Sabarish.

Right now, KadhaiShorts offers micro-dramas for ₹20 per series through a pay-per-series model. Further, the app also offers five free episodes out of the 30-odd episodes that make up a series on average. "So the friction for the person coming into our app is minimal. They pay only for the series they like," says Sabarish. With over 100 titles in production, the platform aims to expand to Telugu, Kannada, Hindi, Malayalam, and Bengali.

This may seem challenging for filmmakers who are used to two or three-hour formats to tell their stories. Vijay Varadharaj, a YouTuber-filmmaker, whose series *Super Bachelors* is streaming on KadhaiShorts, however, is unfazed. "Nothing has changed really. I watch and create Reels, so the vertical format is already in my life." What seems to have taken Vijay by surprise is how enthusiastic KadhaiShorts is about funding vertical cinema. "They were ready to allocate as much funding as they would for a feature film. That's incredible," he says, adding that the new format only reduces costs.

Actor Rohini Molleti, who made *Aval=Avan?* for KadhaiShorts, also says the new format is exciting, especially because every episode has to end with a hook that will entice audiences to return.

"I realised I was taking away everything unnecessary from the script, and that I was capable of writing well," Rohini says, adding how she started recognising the pattern even in many successful commercial feature films. "For instance, in Trivikram Srinivas' *Ala Vaikunthapurramuloo*, you would find a hook every one-and-a-half minutes. He does not waste time on unnecessary tasks; instead, engages with the audience. So I realise that this is an appropriate format for even feature film writing. It is an eye-opener."

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» **PAGE 2**



Style city

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Stepping into S & N by Shantnu Nikhil's first store in Chennai feels like walking into a pristine, curated wardrobe. Shirts are neatly lined up on racks, suits hang in crisp perfection, and the occasional shimmer of sequins bring the drama.

The retail space aligns with the philosophy of designer-duo Shantanu and Nikhil, and what they envision all their stores should feel like. "The philosophy of every store is basically a man coming to his wardrobe," says Nikhil Mehra. "The environment should regulate your nervous system. It should not intimidate, nor should it feel like the brand is trying too hard," he explains.

While the designer-duo burst into the scene nearly 20 years ago with their couture label Shantnu and Nikhil, they launched the prestige-pret extension of their label, S&N by Shantnu Nikhil, in 2020. Envisioned as a bridge-to-luxury label which reimagines occasion dressing for the contemporary customer, there are garments for both men and women spanning bandhgala, draped kurtas, elevated separates, and sculpted gowns.



From bandhgalas to draped kurtas and structured gowns, S&N by Shantnu Nikhil opens their first store in Chennai



Chennai chic (Clockwise from top left) Models don S&N; and Shantanu and Nikhil. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Their retail-driven approach has meant opening 19 stores across the country, with the latest being the ones here in Chennai, as well as in Pune and at Chhatarpur, Delhi.

At Chennai, as in every other city, Nikhil says the brand is keen not to localise the retail experience. Instead, it is banking on consistency and a loyal, repeat customer base. "More than how the store looks, it is about the product and the layout within which we function. We always consider the movement of our clients, much like water finding its way, guiding them to the right shirt, jacket, or kurta," he says.

The fifties are back

The label more recently, had a memorable big screen moment with Akshaye Khanna wearing a bandhgala from S&N in *Dhurandhar*; in the viral scene where he steps out of a car and breaks into a jig to rapper Flipperachi's FA9LA. "The bandhgala really seemed to fit his charm and I was really happy to see that the brand feels diverse enough to be worn not just by personalities, but by characters," he adds.

With men now experimenting with oversized shirts, high waist pants, double pleats, and wide-legged trousers, Nikhil points out that the fifties fashion favourites are making a strong comeback. "Men are focussing on clothes which are not body hugging but personality hugging," he laughs. "There is a big shift from body to personality and it feels like a great time for us."

S&N by Shantnu Nikhil is at the ground floor of Express Avenue Mall, Royapettah. Prices from ₹6,000 onwards.

STEP OUT



With options for vegetarian and non-vegetarian dishes in every course, the highlights include charred foraged mushroom with smoked black sesame jus and flattened rice, grilled chicken marinated in bamboo shoot, seasonal greens tempura with roselle dust, and more.

The Hindu Lit For Life Unplugged x Zhouyu Hosts is on June 5, from 6.30 pm to 7.30 pm. Entry is free but seats are limited. Registration is mandatory. The pop-up is on June 6 and 7 for lunch and dinner at Zyouyu Alwarpet and is priced at ₹3,150 per person. Call 9363036446.

Lit For Life Unplugged

As a part of *The Hindu Lit For Life Unplugged* event in Chennai this weekend, authors Canato Jimo from Nagaland will be sharing insights on art, diversity, folklore, and food. The talk will be on June 5, which will be followed by a five-course dinner by Chef Ahmedaki Laloo from Shillong.

The dinner is a part of Zhouyu Hosts, a culinary series that brings chefs from across India and Asia to Chennai. Chef Ahmedaki — founder of A'Origins, a boutique dining experience in Shillong — is looking forward to introducing Chennaiites to Meghalaya and its food and techniques by way of a five-course meal.

Prathap Nair

It is a sunny morning in May and boulangerie Fournil Didot in the 14th arrondissement of Paris is buzzing with patrons. The industrial oven in the kitchen is spitting out warm baguettes and loaves of airy French bread – Boule de pain – their crusts golden and dusted with flour, dispersing the heady primal scent of fresh bread being baked. Neat little rows of croissants, pain au chocolat, and pastries including macaroons and flans, and sandwiches like jambon-beurre, line the glass counter.

But the bestseller at Didot is their baguette and there is a reason for it. Didot's Baguette – officially Baguette de tradition française – has recently been ranked number one, picked from around 150 (143, to be precise) bakeries around Paris and crowned earlier this year. A jury comprising experts from trade federations, journalists and citizens evaluated each competing baguette based on various factors in an annual competition called Concours de la meilleure baguette de Paris in late February.

Located in a predominantly French-speaking neighbourhood, Fournil Didot is a typical boulangerie as far as French bakeries go in Paris, except for one detail. Its owner, the baguette competition winner, is the Sri Lankan Tamil baker Sithamparappillai Jegatheepan. He is missing this morning because he is accepting his award from Paris's recently elected mayor, Emmanuel Grégoire, at this year's Fête du Pain festival that celebrates the French craft of breadmaking.

"I did not expect to win, so it came as a surprise," Jegatheepan tells me later. Civil war forced Jegatheepan, whose family were farmers in Jaffna, to flee Sri Lanka in 2003. He landed in Italy and travelled to France where he sought asylum.



Baking it big (Clockwise from right) French Baguettes; employees at Didot; Sri Lankan Tamil baker Sithamparappillai Jegatheepan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



Get that bread

Sithamparappillai Jegatheepan, the second Sri Lankan Tamil baker to win the annual baguette competition in Paris, will supply the Elysee Palace for a whole year from June



"Traditional baguette is made only with flour, water, salt, and leaven (yeasty dough). Anyone can perfect the measurements, but the success lies in the fermentation"

SITHAMPARAPPILLAI JEGATHEEPAN Baker

His lack of French language skills restricted his employment opportunities, and he says he took whatever jobs he could find. "One of my first jobs was at a French restaurant that served cuisine from Normandy," he recalls. He started out washing dishes in the kitchen and slowly rose through the ranks to become a cook, a cuisinier, expert at handling prized ingredients like scallops and entrecôte – a premium cut of beef.

By then, cooking, even as he confesses he had little to no experience in it back home in Jaffna, became his professional expertise. In 2008, he joined a French bakery in Paris and learned to make macaroons, a notoriously difficult French pastry to master. In

a decade, with the confidence of a professional baker who learned the ropes of French baking by putting in a lot of blood, sweat, and tears, he became an entrepreneur starting Fournil Didot with a few friends. The bakery was so successful he started another one down the street in 2022.

On the surface, Jegatheepan's story might appear to be one of a passionate small-fish baker rising through the ranks in the roughshod world of French baking to win a prestigious competition. It is all that too, but it is also one of perseverance, where success is not dictated just by passion and hard work but also influenced by circumstances that forced him into the business of gastronomy.

Back at the competition, Jegatheepan's baguette was tested to meet the stringent requirements of the competition for its shape, size, crumb structure resulting from fermentation, and its saltiness. A blind taste test followed that crowned the winner.

"Traditional baguette is made only with flour, water, salt, and leaven (yeasty dough)," he says. "Anyone can perfect the measurements, but the success lies in factors like fermentation." Jegatheepan says his bulk fermentation lasts for 12 hours for every batch of baguette.

The winning carries a prize money of 4,000€ along with a chance to deliver a year-long supply of baguettes to Elysee Palace, the French president's residence, starting June. Jegatheepan had already visited the palace after an invitation, an experience he describes as surreal. "I was introduced to the head chef of the palace, and I got to tell all the kitchen staff about my baking process," he adds.

Paris's annual baguette

competition is increasingly becoming diverse, the winners representing various immigrant subgroups. Jegatheepan himself is the second Sri Lankan to win the competition, the first being Tharshan Selvarajah, who won the competition in 2023 and runs his own bakery bakery Au Levain des Pyrénées in Paris.

The win has brought fame, followed by an increase in his customer-base, he can now also proudly display his certificate in the bakery. "Recently a Korean journalist followed me around because she wanted to observe my work for a whole day," he says, amused.

There have been calls and interview requests from everywhere from both sides of the Atlantic, although none from either India or Sri Lanka until I visited him early May on the day he received his award from the Paris mayor.

The day I visited Didot, Jegatheepan's staff thrust a couple of fresh baguettes into my hands, apologising for his absence. Later as my friend and I savoured it in a nearby café – I pulled it apart and it gave in with a delicious crunch to reveal itself with a mildly nutty and tangy mouthfeel, a result of long fermentation.

People like Jegatheepan's win in the closely gatekept world of French gastronomy represents one simple truth – staking ownership of food traditions is a fool's errand because gastronationalism will crumble in the face of good taste created by talented professionals, no matter their nationality.

For now, Jegatheepan is busy basking in the success of his win and fielding interview requests from around the world. There is a three-year limit on his re-entry in the competition. He will compete again, he says, because the taste of winning is indisputably addictive.

He declares, "The competition is going to get more intense in the coming years, but I'm prepared."

STEPOUT



A tribute in 120 songs

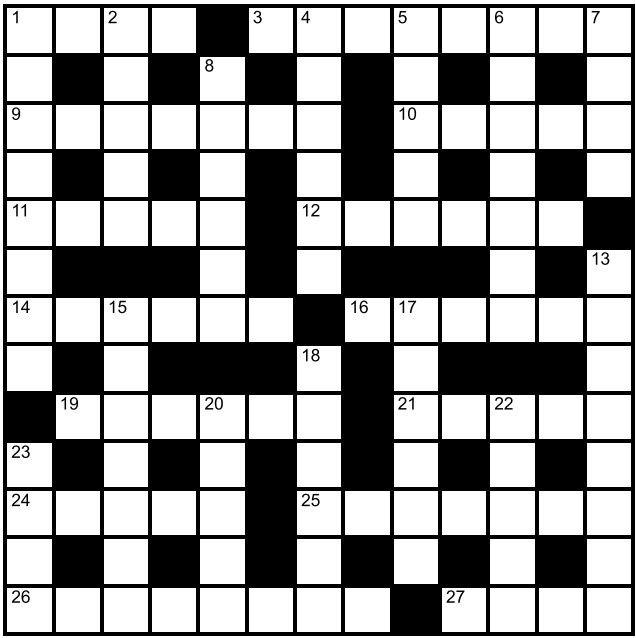
Veena maestro Rajhesh Vaidhya presents Do You Have A Minute? Series – Live, a musical tribute to the legendary S P Balasubrahmanyam. Celebrating the voice that defined generations of memories and milestones, the concert features an ambitious journey through 120 songs in 120 minutes. Through his signature veena renditions, Vaidhya pays homage to SPB's enduring musical legacy in an evening of nostalgia, melody, and remembrance. *On at the Music Academy, Mylapore on June 6 from 7pm onwards. Tickets at bookmyshow starting ₹500.*



Art, pride, and belonging

In the spirit of Pride Month, this weekend, queer voices, stories, and creativity will take center stage as Affections: The Queer Festival, brings together an afternoon of art, music, installations, workshops, food, and community celebration. Hosted by Sunshine House, the festival welcomes members of the LGBTQIA+ community and their allies to a space dedicated to visibility, self-expression, and connection. The festival is a celebration of being queer, openly and loudly, and an invitation to come together in joy, belonging, and pride. *Affections: The Queer Festival is being hosted at Backyard, Adyar on June 7 from 2pm to 8pm. For tickets log on to @thebackyardclan on Instagram. For more details, call 7358458117.*

QUICK CROSSWORD #56 (Set by Doppelganger)



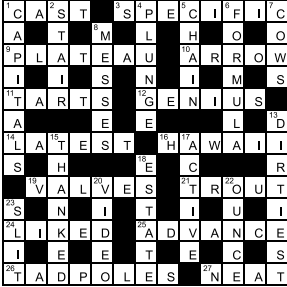
- Across**
- 1 Throw (4)
 - 3 Particular (8)
 - 9 Tableland (7)
 - 10 Pointed weapon (5)
 - 11 Pastries (5)
 - 12 Extraordinary individual (6)
 - 14 Most recent (6)
 - 16 American island state (6)
 - 19 Flow control devices (6)
 - 21 Fish (5)
 - 24 Preferred (5)
 - 25 Move forward (7)
 - 26 Frog larvae (8)
 - 27 Orderly (4)
- Down**
- 1 Uppercases (8)
 - 2 Flights (5)
 - 4 Dive (6)
 - 5 Bond (5)
 - 6 Recipe (7)
 - 7 Subdues (4)
 - 8 Dining halls (6)
 - 13 Most unclean (8)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- 15** Expressed gratitude (7)
- 17** Functioning (6)
- 18** Landed property (6)
- 20** Recorded movie (5)
- 22** Snow leopard (5)
- 23** Narrow opening (4)

Solution No. 56



CONTINUED FROM » PAGE 1

Vijay adds, "When you are writing, you start seeing the hooks. You just need to divide your story accordingly." He states that this format can function even without these hooks. "Even if an episode ends abruptly, the audience will be curious to know what happens next. We have seen that happen on Reels."

Though the vertical screen liberates one from the need for grand sets, the limited space has to be used to its full potential. Rohini says that her team has cracked this in her series. "We had to think out of the box about how we can convey grandeur. The only instance when I missed shooting horizontally was when we were shooting the sea. I couldn't capture it in all its beauty. But this format is taking us to newer horizons." What particularly excites the actor in Rohini was how this format fronts performance. "I can concentrate only on getting the best performances from the actors. I am not dependent on all the other things to take the story forward."

The biggest challenge for KadhaiShorts, Vijay says, would be to get the audience to install yet another application.



"Because Reel creators on Instagram are spending so much to enhance the quality of their content. So the app should have something more, and in that way, the advantage of this app is



The micro-drama market is new, but it is only growing. It offers an ocean of opportunities for creators

SABARISH VENKAT CEO, KadhaiShorts



Kutty stories Posters of a few micro-dramas streaming on Tadka. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Rohini adds, "This isn't going to replace cinema. Someone who wants to make a *Karuppu* – which offers a visual experience – wouldn't opt for this format. But that doesn't mean this is a step down. Wherever you go, whatever you do, your art will always stay."

That said, it does make one wonder if traditional filmmakers see this as yet another invasive medium that makes audiences more complacent. Director PS Mithran, busy working on the Karthi-starrer *Sardar 2*, says, "Micro-dramas will never replace the experience of a theatre watch. Just because we now listen to songs on Spotify doesn't mean we won't attend concerts. No matter how complacent you are in your life, at some point in time, you have to come out, be entertained in a theatre and enjoy a film with a big crowd." He cites how despite being active in the US for quite a few years, micro-dramas have yet to affect the performances of Hollywood films. Micro-dramas might be an untapped market for India but if the upward curve of the format's popularity suggests something, it is that cinema is no longer confined to just horizontal screens.

Vertical limit

that there will be consistent uploads."

Micro-dramas decentralise storytelling, thus allowing filmmakers from second or third-tier cities and towns to make content. "They will also get the confidence that they can make a film. Also, because the screen is small, it drastically reduces production costs," says Vijay.

KadhaiShorts has also launched KadhaiClub, billed as a micro-drama ecosystem aimed to aid creators and democratise storytelling. "For instance, a writer from Sivaganga came up with a script. Our in-house writing team helped him develop it, and a production team helped budget it. We went to Sivaganga and planned our shoots, after which, a

post-production team edited it," says Sabarish.

JioHotstar too has built an open ecosystem. "Here, creators and production partners can participate freely, because category growth accelerates when more people have the opportunity to build within it," says Ambuj. Hotstar's Tadka has released 100+ titles now, intending to have over 1,000 titles by the end of the year.

Vijay believes that newer creators are likely to choose this format. "Those who are already doing films might hesitate because they are already in the industry and have a market and scale. There's a taboo that this is something small, which needs to be broken."

A world framed

Confluence 2026 brings together 191 photographs that capture landscapes, cultures and human stories

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Stepping into the Lalit Kala Akademi feels like crossing a threshold into another world. Within its walls, visitors can wander through the vast deserts of Africa, encounter wildlife frozen in moments of anticipation, stroll through the streets of Egypt, and witness the vibrant colours of Indian festivals, all without leaving Chennai.

The visual journey unfolds through Confluence 2026, the annual photography exhibition organised by the Photographic Society of Madras (PSM). Running until June 8 at the Lalit Kala Akademi, the exhibition showcases 191 photographs by more than 60 photographers, selected from submissions by the society's members.

Chosen by a panel of eminent photographers, including Subrata Bysack, Prema Kakade, and S Balu, the photographs span genres such as Nature, wildlife, landscape, street, architecture, and portraiture, presented in both colour and monochrome. Together, they offer a glimpse into the diverse cultures and human experiences from around the world.

For PSM, Confluence is among its most prestigious annual programmes. "Every year, members of the club from around the world submit entries, from which we select the photographs for display," says GN Ramaswami, chairman, salons and exhibitions, PSM.

The exhibition's legacy is equally remarkable. Founded in 1857 by Alexander Hunter and Walter Elliot, the Photographic Society of Madras is regarded as the world's second-oldest photographic club. Established only a few years after the invention of



Through the lens (Above) A photograph by GN Ramaswami; (below) and visitors at the exhibition. VELANKANNI RAJ B

photography itself, the society has continued to nurture generations of photographers while adapting to the changing media.

Retired photojournalist Rajashekar HK, who has been a club member for many years, says Confluence is a great way to bring together photographers from around the world. "After my retirement, I have continued with my passion for photography; it feels nice to see that on display every year."

The exhibition also pays tribute to two senior members of the Photographic Society of Madras, Ramanidharan R and Vivekanandan PA, who are remembered for their contributions and support to the club over the years.

In their memory, a special section of the gallery displays a selection of their photographs, offering visitors a glimpse into their artistic vision and enduring legacy.

As visitors move from one frame to another, Confluence 2026 becomes more than a photography exhibition; it is a celebration of observation and storytelling.

The exhibition is on till June 8, at Lalit Kala Akademi from 11am to 7pm. Entry is free.



Diya Vakada

At 2am on KNK, the party is anything but over. Strumming guitars can be heard on Khader Nawaz Khan Road, as impromptu jamming sessions take place.

Women and men are in sunglasses at night time – fashion statements that the city is only used to seeing in night clubs. There fried chicken from small restaurants practically tumbling down the street, and film equipment of studio quality being dragged through bollards.

There is a crowd that sings along to Tamil songs, with parts of English songs thrown in on occasion. Numbers grow as the night progresses, and those passing by are welcomed and encouraged to join in or just watch and vibe along. This is not an unusual night on this newly remodelled stretch. "It wasn't a planned thing at all," says Nilaa, an influencer witnessing the session. "It is really sweet and wholesome to see."

KNK reopened in February this year following months of construction. After the revamp it has been dubbed Chennai's attempt at recreating Bengaluru's Church Street. The similarities are evident with the cobblestone road, popular restaurants, and incessant flow of influencers shooting reels.

As the sun starts to set and Chennai's weather becomes more bearable, the college-going crowd claims the walkways. The road is illuminated with tall white streetlights, making it incredibly well lit come nighttime, and encourages one to stay for as long as they might want to. People sit to talk, pose audaciously for pictures,

Cobble it up

Khader Nawaz Khan Road recently seems to have made way for a bustling pedestrian culture in Chennai



or ramble around as they take a break from cafe hopping. Many carry professional cameras with the hope of capturing interesting scenes. "This is a great backdrop to film things," says Amit, who says he is shooting a short film. He

holds a camera in one hand and wildly gesticulates with the other to get his shot. "You see a lot of interesting people. There's a lot that can be done with the space." As you wander around, there is a silence uncharacteristic of most

CHENNAI, TAMILNADU, 02.06.2026: (FOR METRO PLUS) KNK Road story for Metro Plus. Photo Ravindran R/ The Hindu. THE HINDU

Stop. Eat. Go

- Wondering where to go out dancing? Check out the DJs who play at Secret Story.
- Soul by Dair provides delicious smash burgers that can be grabbed and eaten on the street.
- Besides coffee in cones, Double Quotes now has a summer menu that now features mango desserts. Cones mandatory.
- The Old Cheese Bar becomes a heaven for cheese lovers with live cheese wheels, pastas, and a chocolate raclette that drips chocolate over desserts.
- Batter life is the great stop for desserts, with the option of pairing ice cream with different dessert batters and serving indulgent ice cream sundaes.

streets in Chennai. Wide pavements with benches and large spaces for public seating have been favoured, discouraging traffic and all the unpleasant chaos it comes with. With limited cars allowed inside and a variety of seating areas, this is a place people can go to without a specific agenda in mind.

That is not to say that it lacks bars and cafes. If you want to grab a bite but do not want to leave the road, Melt or Tempt that provide fried chicken, fries, poppers, and smash burgers that can be grabbed and eaten on the street.

Coffee options are aplenty at KNK. Try Double Quotes, Latte, and Madras Coffee House for different types of cuppas.

Moore Market opened earlier in March. It is a small store in the corner of the street whose gothic decor makes the cafe hard to miss. It provides a selection of books and games for those looking for a quiet and cozy experience.

And if things get too overwhelming, one could step into Roc-A-Coe, a 1930s-style cocktail bar to forget about the world outside for some time. All these places add to the charm of KNK, but the sidewalk manages to one-up them all. All that must be done is to follow the cobblestone road.

When princess Hamlet speaks

Adishakti Theatre's *A Woman or Not To Be* reimagines Shakespeare's Hamlet as a young woman, using the classic tragedy to explore gender, agency, and emotional freedom

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"To be, or not to be: that is the question." More than four centuries after William Shakespeare's Hamlet first posed this existential dilemma, Adishakti Theatre's upcoming play, *A Woman or Not To Be*, returns to the classic tragedy but with a twist: what if Hamlet were a woman?

Written and directed by Vinay Kumar and presented by Shreya Nagarajan Singh Arts Development Consultancy, the play at Alliance Française of Madras on June 6 reimagines Shakespeare's troubled prince as Princess Hamlet, a young woman navigating grief, rage, suspicion and a relentless search for justice. At a time when we are still struggling with women's rights, the production uses Hamlet's story to examine larger questions of male privilege, revenge, emotional freedom and how society responds differently to women who express anger.

The idea for the play came from disturbing news that Vinay encountered about a young woman who was attacked after rejecting a man's proposal, which eventually led him back to Shakespeare's text.

Hamlet here is a modern young woman who loves manga and anime. One day, she receives the devastating news from home, only to find her mother, the



Spotlight Cast of A Woman or Not To Be. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Queen, murdered, and her aunt now married to her father. In her dream, her mother's ghostly figure urges her not to seek revenge but to protect herself



The play asks questions about revenge, emotional freedom, and how society shapes our responses to both. We present those questions and allow people to arrive at their own conclusions

NIMMY RAPHAEL
Actor

and complete her education. "When I looked at Hamlet and other canonical works, I began asking what ethical difference exists between these acts and the violence we continue to see around us today," says Vinay. Vinay began wondering whether Hamlet's actions and agency would be viewed differently if the character were female. "If Hamlet is a princess instead of a prince, will she get the same agency that the male Hamlet gets?" he asks. "Will she be allowed to brood, seek revenge, and pursue justice in the same way?" Unlike the original Hamlet set

in Denmark, Vinay's play defies geographical boundaries to represent women from all parts of the world. For him, the major challenge was to write it from a female lens. "The discourse is a feminist realm, and I am a privileged man writing it, so I had to be extra cautious about the script."

Playing Princess Hamlet is Nimmy Raphael, who was involved in the production's development from its earliest stages. As part of Adishakti's collaborative laboratory process, actors engage with the work long before a final script emerges. For Nimmy, portraying a female Hamlet required creating an entirely new emotional landscape. "The challenge was finding the right balance of emotion so that her voice is not dismissed as irrational or hysterical. That is something this Hamlet struggles with because society constantly shapes and restricts how women are allowed to express emotion," she says.

"We are not telling audiences what to think," says Nimmy. "The play asks questions about revenge, emotional freedom, and how society shapes our responses to both. We present those questions and allow people to arrive at their own conclusions."

A Women or Not to Be will be on at Alliance Française of Madras, on June 6 from 5pm to 7.30pm (two slots). Tickets at ₹250 on shreyanagarajansingh.com



Style meets charm

Studio Trioss presents a fashion and lifestyle exhibition showcasing a curated selection of Indo-western wear, chic casuals,

menswear, jewellery, handcrafted footwear, baked treats, and home décor. Visitors can browse through a wide range of offerings. @The Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah. On June 4 and 5, from 10.30am to 8pm. For details, call 9840105010.



Explore rhythm

An exhibition of contemporary paintings by Rajesh R V, The Magnificent Life explores a world where coexistence replaces control.

The artist envisions a return to a shared rhythm of life — one in which humans, animals, and Nature exist in harmony. It explores the world's interconnectedness. @Forum Art Gallery, Adyar. June 10 to August 8. 11am to 7pm. For details, call 8787826960.



Wicked and whacky

Meet the team behind upcoming dark comedy, *Maa Behen*, starring Madhuri Dixit and Triptii Dimri

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After stepping into the melodramatic, violent world of Vishal Bhardwaj's bloody actioner, *O'Romeo*, and exuding intensity with her presence in Shazia Iqbal's scathing political drama, *Dhadak 2*, Triptii Dimri is back with lighter shades in *Maa Behen*. The upcoming Netflix film places her in a middle-class neighbourhood in a North Indian town, sharing a complicated bond with her chirpy sister (Dharna Durga) and dramatic mother (Madhuri Dixit). Triptii channels a restless energy to bring out her character's quirkiness, which is sharpened by her earthy, heartland Hindi accent.

The actor says it was fun to learn the dialect. "We knew that we didn't want a strong accent in the film, but just get the local dialect right with necessary flourishes. So, we practised with our dialect coach, Ganesh, who would ask us to react to certain things, make us sing songs, and do exercises that helped us navigate the language," says Triptii.

Director Suresh Triveni started writing *Maa Behen* in 2019 after the success of his debut *Tumhari Sullu*, a comedy-drama with an emotional touch. He wanted his next to be "a whacky film, full of wicked humour".

"The title of the film came to me first. Our producer, Vikram Malhotra, was quite excited about the one-line idea. He asked me to write quickly, and I think the pressure caught up to me," Suresh quips, adding how he couldn't complete the story until he met writer Pooja Tolani. "Everything came into place in 2024," he says. It was also in

2024 that Triptii starred in a range of comedies, breaking away from her earlier mould of doing offbeat, sentimental mood pieces. Reflecting on doing comedy, Triptii says, "I find it very difficult; it is not easy to make people laugh. A lot of it depends on the writing and the equation you share with your co-actors as well."

Her co-actor, Dharna, adds, "I think the kind of environment you are working in helps in facilitating comedy. It's also important to share a level of quirkiness with your co-actors to create an impact."

About the toughest part of directing a comedy, Suresh states, "You change camera angles plenty of times and have to maintain the tone throughout. It is also largely dependent on the actors' ability to deliver the dialogues in a certain manner," says Suresh.

The director also feels that in *Maa Behen*, audiences will get to see "a new Triptii Dimri". Is there any difference in the way she chooses her scripts now? "From the beginning, I have decided to work in films where I really connect with the characters. That's been my intent since the start, and it will stay the same moving forward," she says.

Maa Behen will be available to stream on Netflix from June 5



Lasting notes
Singer SP Charan, son of late legendary singer SPB. THAMODHARAN B

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It was supposed to be a simple drive. It changed SP Charan's life.

Late in the Nineties, on a balmy day, Charan offered to drop his father, popular singer SP Balasubramanyam, at Ilayaraaja's studios for a song recording. "It's so vivid in my mind. My father was learning the track when Ilayaraaja uncle walked in. I was just sitting in a corner when he noticed me. "Oh, you are back from the US? What are you planning to do in life?", to which I mumbled something about setting up a business."

And then, Ilayaraaja asked him the inevitable - "Do you sing?"

A nervous Charan again mumbled something about singing occasionally, without realising what was in store for him. "*Nalla naal lam pakkam venam* (Let's not wait for a good today). Today you will sing."

With those words, 'chauffeur' Charan became 'singer' Charan. "It was supposed to be a male duet between Ilayaraaja and SPB. He isolated a couple of lines in that song and made me sing. When I went to the booth, both these people were standing right next to me...imagine my plight," he recalls with a guffaw, about his debut 'Unnakoruthi' track from *Purniyavathi*. Thankfully, the two noticed his nervousness and left him alone to sing what would become a memorable debut. Charan has henceforth

Finding my voice

On SPB's 80th birth anniversary, we sit down with SP Charan on why his late legendary father was special to music and cinema fans

become a much sought-after singer, teaming up with major Tamil music composers. But his biggest draw today - he admits rather candidly - is the fact that he sings most of his late legendary father's songs with Ilayaraaja on many stages. "With Appa not being there and with Ilayaraaja kind of approving me singing his songs, I feel more confident."

What's in vogue? Charan's voice might be familiar now, but a younger version of him did not want to do anything with music. Armed with an education in the US, Charan arrived back in Chennai to make inroads as a film producer. "I never wanted to get into singing. Appa was flying high then, and it was detrimental for any singer to match his music standards and the kind of professionalism he brought



SPB 80: What to expect

Charan is putting together 'SPB 80', a grand tribute show in the city. Featuring professional singers like Vijay Yesudas, Karthik, Saindhavi and Shweta Mohan, the event promises to celebrate all things SPB. Charan, himself, will be singing a few rare numbers. "I do not want it to be the run-of-the-mill show where we repeat the same tracks we sing on most stages," says Charan, who is looking forward to crooning songs like 'Solai Poovil', 'Vaan Nila' and 'Kadavul Amaithu.' "I want it to be a journey through decades of SPB songs, where listeners turn nostalgic."

to his craft. For me, to be in that space, was nerve-racking," he reveals. If singing was by accident, production was a path he consciously chose - the result of which was films *Chennai 600028* and *Aaranya Kaandam*, among others.

Beyond their critical acclaim, were these projects commercially viable? "No. They were purely passion projects and done because the story idea excited us. It's not that I spent lavishly, but I never worked on post-production processes,

revenues, numbers and market avenues. If I had to rework them now, I would approach them with different budgets."

With the advent of OTT platforms, would he reconsider production? "Not at all. I've had enough. With OTT platforms, you need a big name; like, for music, you would have to opt for a name that is trending now, while I would rather go to Yuvan or Raja or Vidyasagar. I'm so not suitable for the film industry now as a producer."

What Charan is currently more comfortable doing is digging into songs that his father has left behind. He is getting his own share of tracks - 'Sarkarey Solliruchu' from *Lenin Pandian* being the latest - but fans still expect him to fill the void left behind by SPB. "When Appa was around, people said that I sounded like the SPB of the Seventies. And now, when I sing, people exclaim that I sound exactly like him. Someone said that they are not missing him as I have replaced him. I don't think I will ever get a separate space for myself."

But it's not something that bothers him greatly now. Because, as he puts it, "my voice is my voice." There are times when he feels otherwise. "Sometimes, when I sing on stage, I hear myself in the monitors and think: 'God, I sound just like dad.' I'm made my peace with it now."

'SPB 80' will take place on June 14 at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall. For tickets, log on to District by Zomato

The man who asked questions

Who was Sathyendra? The cinephile, whose viral *Leo* review made headlines, passed away recently. Chennai's film community came together to say goodbye

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Life has all the answers. Only, you need to ask the right questions.

Sathyendra knew this well. This actor, theatre artist, translator and film critic - and a well-known face in Chennai's creative spaces - passed away recently. In an unexpected wave of support, the city's film and arts community rose to the occasion, collaborating to contact with his family and coordinating for a funeral.

So, who was Sathyendra? If you have ever been to a film festival or screening, or a literature panel discussion in the city, chances are you would have seen him. Usually clad in a kurta and wearing a *jolna* bag, typical of old-timers in the city, Sathyendra's would routinely be the first hand to rise when the floor is opened for the question and answer session. His questions were mostly pointed and direct. Sometimes, even aggressive, thus eliciting a

squirm from the panel members or audience. At times, the host would move on to other questions. But for Sathyendra, it did not matter. The questions had to be asked, and he would have to be the one asking them. "He loved to get attention," points out filmmaker-writer K Hariharan, who cast Sathyendra in his *Ezhavathi Manidhan* (1982), "He had a child-like quality and could not keep aloof."

That Sathyendra would - in the corridors of Chennai's Max Mueller Bhavan or Alliance Francaise, places he would frequent to attend lectures and social events. If he was not there, he would be in the cinema halls; Sathyendra's viral moment, in fact, came when he gave a scathing review for Vijay-starrer *Leo*.

But, where in Chennai did Sathyendra exactly live? Who were his family and friends? Those are answers people seldom knew then. They still don't.

Hailing from Tiptur in Karnataka, Sathyendra left



home for Madras chasing name and fame. Sathyendra's move to the then Madras in 1981, armed with just Rs 300 and a list of Tamil filmmakers he wanted to work with, was the biggest decision he made. *Ezhavathi Manidhan*, directed by Hariharan, is considered among his big films. Sathyendra also reportedly played minor roles in *Man*

Vasanai, *Sathya* and *Kadamai Kanniyam Kattupaadu*. "We were not very close to each other, but we were never indifferent to the other," reveals multidisciplinary artist Pravin Kannanur, "Actors Kalairamani, Pasupathi, Jayakumar, Prasad all made it to Sathya's funeral, as did Nasser and documentarist RV Ramani. We had all known him from the

Sathendra never felt offended if his question was not answered; he would be happy that he had asked it in the first place.

K HARIHARAN,
Filmmaker

For the arts
Actor and film critic Sathyendra.

late Eighties, learning clowning and miming at the same workshops. We would emerge from a Ghatak film or a Tarkovsky, and he would articulate something I'd missed entirely." He adds, "Sathya taught himself cinema, languages, survival, and eked a living from it and in moments when that didn't work, he would ask any one of us: 'Why don't you offer me tea? Or: 'Can you buy my ticket to Thrissur? I'm catching ITFOK.' He was treating his acquaintances as collaborators in his survival."

While Sathyendra grew up watching Tamil films, he loved world cinema too. He was, in fact, a regular at the Chennai International Film Festival, affirms Emanadar Thangaraj of the Indo Cine Appreciation Foundation. "He (Sathyendra) was an ardent film lover and excellent critic," says

Thangaraj, "He would give a critical view of the films with authenticity."

Kennedi Gopalan, a vedic astrologer and actor-filmmaker, writes on X about how Sathyendra and Tamil film editor B Lenin once screened a short film titled *Knock Out* about a forgotten Indian boxing champion who dies unrecognised on the streets. Sathyendra played the role of the dead boxer, and in a bizarre turn of events, he ended up the same way as the character he played as well: with no one around at the Royapettah mortuary, until word of his plight spread around. Tamil cinema swiftly acted, with actor Vishal directing the staff of the Nadigar Sangam to pitch in. Premallatha Vijayakant also offered assistance on humanitarian grounds.

Sathyendra's life may have erratic but he will be remembered in Chennai as the film enthusiast who always asked questions. Some of them, unfortunately, will remain unanswered.